

## Japan's Kojima Has History of Making Blue Jeans

In the Japanese town of Kojima, the main road is named Jeans Street.

This street is where people from around the world come to visit. The drink machines at the train station have images of jeans on them. The roads are painted blue, with the lines at the edges colored pink and white, the trademark of Kojima jeans' seams.

With about 40 jeans manufacturers and stores, including cafes, the area gets about 100,000 visitors a year, the Japan National Tourism Organization said.

Japanese jeans are often costly, dark and durable. Although a small part of the global jeans market, Japanese jean makers have developed a reputation for quality and attention to detail.

Pairs of jeans flap over Jeans Street in Kojima, Okayama prefecture, Japan, on Sept. 4, 2024. (AP Photo/Yuri Kageyama)

Kojima is where popular brands like Big John are made. The city now supplies international clothing brands, including Gucci.

Emma McClendon of St. John's University in New York said that the Japanese industry has not taken a mass marketing path. Instead, the jean industry pays careful attention to creating quality products that collectors might like.

In Kojima, Jeans Street is small and uncrowded. Each company in the area is small, hiring about 100 people.

What you will find are workers taking pride in "monozukuri," or "making things." The term suggests careful attention to detail.

This idea can be found throughout Japan, from carmakers to the local tofu store.

"More like making a kimono" is the way Yoshiharu Okamoto, a dyeing craftsman at Kojima-based manufacturer Momotaro Jeans, puts it.

His hands and nails are colored blue from putting threads of cotton into a big container of coloring called dye.

He knows by smell and feel the right state of the indigo coloring, which he compares to a living thing. He says it is a 365-days-a-year job, as the dye has to be checked and mixed every day.

"It's not that easy to get this special color," Okamoto told the Associated Press recently. "It's my life."

The dark color is so special it has earned the name “Japan blue” or “tokuno blue,” meaning “especially concentrated blue.”

Jeans made in Kojima are costly. The jeans can cost from \$230 per pair to \$1,400 or more.

Naomi Takebayashi, a seamstress at Momotaro Jeans, hand-stitches a pair of jeans in Kojima, Okayama prefecture, western Japan, on Sept. 4, 2024. (AP Photo/Ayaka McGill)

Thomas Stege Bojer is founder of Denimhunters, an online site for people who like jeans and the cotton material they are made out of — denim.

He says Japanese brands use “raw denim” that ages well and lasts a long time. He pointed to the jeans as part of a movement known as “slow clothing.”

The idea is to produce fewer, but higher quality pieces of clothing. The movement came as a reaction to low-cost, mass-produced clothes.

“We just make too many clothes...I think, and we need to slow down,” Bojer said from his home near Copenhagen, Denmark.

McClendon said the Japanese industry is “shifting the conversation around jeans to be about heritage elements, about educating consumers on historical details as a form of quality.”

Momotaro Jeans, for example, come with a lifetime guarantee. Tears and other problems get fixed at no cost, within reason.

Japan Blue Co., which runs Momotaro, a brand that began in 2006, said yearly sales totaled about \$11 million for the latest year. About 40 percent of sales come from outside Japan.

Masataka Suzuki, president and chief operating officer at Japan Blue, said the area has a strong industrial history.

In the past, industry centered around sewing heavy materials, including military clothes and obi sashes for kimonos, as well as the cotton and indigo-dyeing native to the area.

The jeans are for life, Suzuki said. The jeans slowly change depending on how they are worn and how the wearer lives.

“We want to create a product that is a testament to a person’s life,” he said.

I'm John Russell.

Yuri Kageyama reported on this story for the Associated Press. John Russell adapted it for VOA Learning English.

## Vocabulary

---

jeans - n. กางเกงขายาวที่มักทำจากผ้ายีนส์

trademark - n. ลักษณะหรือคุณสมบัติที่เชื่อมโยงกับบุคคลหรือสิ่งของอย่างชัดเจน

seam - n. การเชื่อมต่อของผ้าสองชิ้นด้วยการเย็บ มักจะอยู่ใกล้ขอบ

durable - adj. แข็งแรงและสามารถใช้งานได้นาน

reputation - n. ความคิดเห็นที่ผู้คนมีต่อบริษัทหรือบุคคล

brand - n. ผลิตภัณฑ์ชนิดหนึ่งที่มีชื่อซึ่งเป็นที่รู้จักของผู้คนจำนวนมาก

kimono - n. เครื่องแต่งกายประจำชาติญี่ปุ่นแบบดั้งเดิม ประกอบด้วยเสื้อคลุมยาวแขนกว้าง

dye - v. การทำให้เกิดสีใหม่และมักจะเป็นสีถาวร

craftsman - n. ผู้ที่มีทักษะในงานฝีมือ

concentrated - adj. หนาแน่นมาก หรือ เข้มข้นมาก

conversation - n. การแลกเปลี่ยนความคิดเห็นหรือแนวคิดด้วยวาจา

heritage - n. ประเพณีหรือมรดกทางวัฒนธรรม

testament - n. หลักฐานหรือเครื่องยืนยัน

## Reading Comprehension Quiz

---

**1. What is the name of the main road in the Japanese town of Kojima?**

Denim Street

Kojima Boulevard

Jeans Street

Fashion Avenue

**2. Which of the following is NOT a distinctive feature of Jeans Street in Kojima?**

Drink machines with images of jeans at the train station.

Roads painted blue.

Pink and white lines at the edges of the roads, resembling jeans seams.

Large billboards displaying international jean brands.

**3. Approximately how many visitors does the jeans-related area in Kojima attract annually?**

About 40,000 visitors.

About 100,000 visitors.

About 230,000 visitors.

About 1,400,000 visitors.

**4. According to the article, what is a key characteristic of Japanese jeans?**

They are usually inexpensive and light-colored.

They are known for being costly, dark, and durable.

They prioritize mass production over quality.

They are designed for quick fashion trends.

**5. Which international clothing brand is mentioned as being supplied by Kojima?**

Levi's

Gucci

Calvin Klein

Zara

**6. Emma McClendon of St. John's University describes the Japanese jean industry's approach as:**

Focusing on mass marketing for global reach.

Prioritizing quantity over craftsmanship.

Paying careful attention to creating quality products for collectors.

Producing low-cost, disposable fashion items.

**7. What is mentioned about the size of individual companies on Jeans Street in Kojima?**

They are large corporations employing thousands.

They are small, typically hiring about 100 people.

They are mostly family-run businesses with fewer than 10 employees.

The article does not specify company size.

**8. What does the term "monozukuri" imply about workers in Kojima?**

Their focus on rapid production.

Their commitment to mass marketing strategies.

Their pride in making things with careful attention to detail.

Their preference for automated manufacturing.

**9. Yoshiharu Okamoto, a dyeing craftsman, compares the process of making jeans to what traditional Japanese craft?**

Origami

Tea ceremony

Kimono making

Calligraphy

**10. Why does Okamoto describe his job with indigo dyeing as a '365-days-a-year job'?**

He works every day, including holidays, to meet demand.

The dye needs to be constantly checked and mixed daily.

He has to travel to collect new dye materials every day.

It takes a full year to complete one batch of dye.

**11. What special names have been given to the dark blue color of Kojima jeans?**

Ocean blue and deep blue.

Kojima blue and craftsman blue.

Japan blue and tokuno blue.

Indigo blue and authentic blue.

**12. What is the approximate price range for a pair of jeans made in Kojima?**

\$50 to \$100

\$150 to \$200

\$230 to \$1,400 or more

Prices are not mentioned in the article.

**13. According to Thomas Stege Bojer, what is the core idea behind 'slow clothing'?**

To produce clothes at a slower pace to reduce manufacturing costs.

To focus on mass production with eco-friendly materials.

To produce fewer, but higher quality pieces of clothing.

To create garments that take a long time to sew by hand.

**14. How does Emma McClendon suggest the Japanese industry is changing the conversation around jeans?**

By focusing on trendy designs and celebrity endorsements.

By emphasizing heritage elements and educating consumers on historical details as a form of quality.

By promoting them as affordable everyday wear.

By expanding into new global markets with aggressive advertising.

**15. What percentage of Momotaro Jeans' yearly sales come from outside Japan?**

Approximately 10 percent.

Approximately 25 percent.

Approximately 40 percent.

Approximately 60 percent.